caste from his own, unless it is more noble and more exalted than his own.' One caste, Haldrkkors, is 'only occupied in removing the refuse from houses, it gets the remains of what the others eat, of whatever caste they may be, and it does not make any scruple about eating indifferently of all things. [Its members] alone feed pigs and use them for food'.[4]

With barely concealed horror, Bernier also relates events from the famous 'car' festival of the Jagannath Temple in Orissa (similar to the chariot festival described by Niccolo de Conti in Vijayanagar):

> A superb wooden machine [with] many grotesque figures . . . is set on fourteen or sixteen wheels like those of a gun-carriage, and drawn or pushed along by the united exertions of fifty or sixty persons. The idol, Jagannat, placed conspicuously in the middle, richly attired, and gorgeously adorned, is thus conveyed from one temple to another . . . blindly credulous [people] throw themselves upon the ground in the way of its ponderous wheels, which pass over and crush to atoms the bodies of the wretched fanatics without exciting the horror or surprise of the spectators. No deed, according to their estimation, is so heroic or meritorious as this self-devotion: the victims believe that Jagannat will receive them as children, and recall them to life in a state of happiness and dignity.

Bernier derides Brahmins who 'promote these gross errors and superstitions to which they are indebted for their wealth and consequence'. Though 'held in general veneration', 'their tricks and impostures' are 'wicked and detestable'. 'Lustful priests' even deceive and possess young girls dedicated to serve the deity at Jagannath Temple. He claims, 'The Great Mogol, though a Mahometan, permits these ancient and superstitious practices; not wishing, or not daring, to disturb the Gentiles in the free exercises of their religion.'

He then focuses on the 'melancholy fact' of sati, relating many harrowing cases that he has seen. He is certain that many widows 'would willingly have recanted, if recantation had been permitted by the merciless Brahmens; but those demons excite or astound the affrighted victims, and even thrust them into the fire'. Citing an example, he writes that a young woman on the burning pyre was 'prevented from escaping by the long poles of the diabolical executioners'. In another, the Brahmins pushed 'the unwilling victim toward the fatal spot, seated her on the wood, tied her hands and feet, lest she should run away, and in that situation the innocent creature was burnt alive'. Bernier doesn't mince words, 'I need scarcely say how much my own indignation has been excited, and how ardently I have wished for opportunities to exterminate those cursed Brahmens.' He clarifies, too, that any widow who manages to 'avoid the impending sacrifice, cannot hope to pass her days in happiness, or to be treated with respect or affection . . . she is ever afterwards exposed to the ill-treatment of